

CHAPTER 6: FIND INVADERS. GET PRISONERS.

Catria and Erik ran as quickly as they could back to the war mage gym, knowing there were Phyrnians looking around.

As soon as they ran in, they called for Rhys and told him what they saw. He immediately ordered all the war mages to go out, look for the Phyrnians, and attract their attention, so the Cruian team could get out with Xena unnoticed.

Catria could feel her heart racing. War mages were not supposed to fight outside the arena, but at the same time, she had to stop the Phyrnians. She gave Erik a quick hug goodbye.

He kissed her on the forehead, wished her luck, and then went with his team while she went with hers.

The kiss on the forehead was calming and energizing at the same time, and Catria felt she could conquer any problem, but still felt a loss that Erik was leaving. Hopefully, he and his team would get away with Xena

and not have her noticed.

Yet, there wasn't time to think. She had to go with her team.

They all headed out and started looking around, in pairs. She was with Hrod.

"What do we do if we find the Phyrnians?" Catria whispered as they searched.

"Try to capture them instead of kill," Hrod answered. "If we kill them we can be put to death for fighting outside the arena. No blood is to be drawn."

"But they are invading our city," Catria countered. "It's not wrong to defend ourselves or our people."

Hrod tightened his lips. "It won't matter. If we spill blood outside of the arena in defense, it will save us from death, but not from a sound beating."

Catria clung to his arm, and the both continued the search silently.

Everything went well until they found a group of Phyrnians. There were a half-dozen, one that Hrod recognized as a war mage.

"Do we go for help?" Catria whispered.

"No," Hrod whispered back. "They'll get away if we do. We make noise and hope help comes."

Catria tensed. "What if more of theirs come?"

"Then we try not to die," Hrod stated. He then motioned for her to follow and moved closer, trying to

not be seen.

When he came close enough, he stepped from behind the trees and called to them, “Surrender! You are trespassing.” He knew it wouldn’t work, but he had to give them the chance. As expected, they all attacked. His first strike was at the war mage, Bruis. Bruis was big and strong, as most Phyrnian war mages, and fought with a battle axe. Hrod had fought against him before. Fighting battle axes was hard, and they took down shielding quickly. Fortunately, Hrod was starting with full shielding even after the sparring that morning.

Unfortunately, Hrod didn’t get to just fight Bruis. The other Phyrnians were not war mages, but they were strong and also attacked.

Catria fought two of them, but she really had no idea how to fight a group.

The battle was hard, and Catria screamed loudly for help. Honestly, she was happy that her staff wasn’t edged, as she really didn’t want to slice the Phyrnians attacking up. She had shielding. They didn’t. Her shielding didn’t go down much because every time a hard strike came against her, Hrod threw himself between her and the attacker, but he took so many hits doing so.

His shielding went down pretty quickly, and Catria panicked when he took a hit from the battle axe, and blood spattered all over.

She dropped down beside him to heal him, but everyone came to attack her. Suddenly a flash of light

came from her as she tried to push people away, and they flew back.

Yet, she couldn't keep pushing them back. She had to heal Hrod. He'd been like a brother to her most of her life.

She was ecstatic to see that Erik suddenly galloped in on his horse. He jumped off, whipped his whip around, and all the attackers flew back as if they'd been struck even if they weren't touched.

As he fought, Catria focused on healing Hrod, and soon, the other war mages from her team arrived.

The fight around her didn't take long with so many war mages and only one on the Phyrnian side.

"How are you?" she asked as Hrod sat up.

"Amazingly good," Hrod answered. "I thought I was going to die, but your healing is good."

She smiled, gave him a hug, and then ran over to Erik. "What are you doing here? I thought you went back to Cruia.

"I was worried about you, so I asked Dillion if I could help and come home after I did. He approved."

Catria threw her arms around him. "You're my hero."

He winked at her and joked, "Then maybe I can get a hero's kiss."

She blushed a cherry red but admitted, "I'd like that."

He didn't give it to her then because Rhys called over,

“Come, everyone. Let’s get the prisoners to the castle. This needs to be brought to King Hamill.

They did all head to the castle. King Hamill was not happy that Phyrnians were looking around without permission to be in the land, likely up to mischief.

Rhys was given the task of questioning the Phyrnians. He personally took Bruis’s weapon and had him tied to a chair with a kusari-gama from a retired war mage, so it could hold Bruis.

“What are you doing sneaking around our land?” Rhys demanded.

“Looking for Xena,” Bruis hissed back. “Give her back to us.”

Rhys raised his eyebrows. “Xena? Did you lose one of your people?”

“You’re hiding her! I know it!” Rhys insisted. “Return her! We have the right to kill you for hiding her.”

“We aren’t hiding her,” Rhys corrected. “I swear that she is not in Terrian.”

“You lie!” Bruis seethed. “She spoke of Terrian, thinking it isn’t the pit of demons it is.” He jerked, trying to break free and attack Rhys, but he couldn’t.

Bruis didn’t give anymore answers, but likely there wasn’t too much more. Rhys asked about Slayde when Bruis insisted Xena was to return home and marry him, but Bruis would say nothing more.

It was pretty obvious that Bruis, despite being a war

mage was afraid of Slayde. Likely many people were.

When the interrogation was over, King Hamill commanded that all the Phyrnians get locked up. They definitely had cells made to contain a war mage if needed.

It was very late at night when they all returned to the gym.

Most of the team raided the kitchen to see what there was to eat.

Catria buttered some bread for a late night snack and went and sat down by Hrod.

“Thanks,” he said to her after finishing a bite of a meat pie that had been leftover from lunch. “You saved my life today. Your power is strong.”

Catria finished her bite. “I have so much to learn. I was helpful healing, but not fighting. Do you think I’ll have to fight in the arena much?”

Hrod suddenly stiffened. “Unfortunately, you might. The Phyrnians think we are hiding Xena, and we caught several of there men, including Bruis. On the next battle day, Phyrn is going to come after us with a vengeance.”

Catria clutch his arm, wishing Erik hadn’t had to leave. “Do you really think they will attack with no proof that we have Xena?”

Hrod looked straight in her eyes and warned, “I’m sure of it.”